

Using OSM

There are several ways of using OSM to simply view the map or to view the data contained within. You can use OSM irrespective of the device or the operating system that you have.

In the browser: Simply visit <http://openstreetmap.org> (or osm.org). You can change the *base map* by clicking on the little drop-down box at the top right-hand side of the map, and choosing a map (from Cycle Map, Transport Map or the Mapquest Open Map). When viewing the map, aerial imagery is *not* available, due to licence restrictions (or it won't be free, so get over it).

After you zoom into the map to a reasonable level, you can view the *map data* by clicking on the drop-down arrow adjacent to the *Edit* link above the map. It is also possible to export the map data as XML, or an image, by clicking on *Export*. This way, you can download parts of the map to make roughly printed-out paper maps.

On your Android device: For Android, there's an excellent application called OSMAnd. You can download it either from the Play Store or from the *F-Droid* application for Android.

Contributing to OSM

Remember that using OSM and letting your friends know about it is in itself a 'contribution'. That said, you might want to enhance the data for your town or area. OSM provides incredibly detailed maps with several features. On a sufficiently populated map, you should be able to find the location of the nearest ATM of a particular bank, an eatery of your preference, or just about anything else you might want—just by looking at the map. But that's a result of hundreds of contributions by people like you, driven by necessity and interest. I myself started out by mapping my hometown, and I've been mapping since then.

Editing the map

There are several things that can be edited. One can either correct something that's askew, or add something that should be present on



OSMAnd Startup Screen



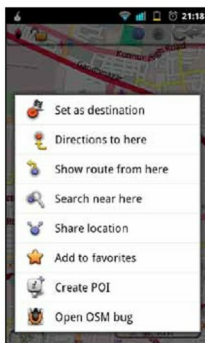
Basic map view

the map, but isn't. Most entities can be represented using one of the following:

- A node/point of interest
- A path/way
- A shape/area/polygon

There are no curves or circles that you can add. You have to add more points to represent a curve.

Map editors have tools that you can use to draw details on the map.



Touch and hold screen to bring up basic navigation tools



Settings screen

The primary tool is a *node editor*, which can be used to draw nodes. Two or more nodes make a path. If the path loops in on itself, it's an area or a polygon. A node represents a *point of interest (POI)* or any entity that can be simply represented using a single node. Examples are post-boxes, public telephone booths, ATM kiosks, etc.